

The Heart

The heart is a muscular organ about the size of a fist. It pumps blood through the whole body.

An adult heart beats about 72 times per minute at rest. A child's heart beats a little faster.

Chambers

The heart has four chambers. The two upper chambers are called atria.

The two lower chambers are called ventricles. The left ventricle is the strongest chamber.

Blood Flow

Blood leaves the heart through the aorta, the largest artery in the body.

Veins carry blood back to the heart. Valves stop blood from flowing backwards.

History

William Harvey described the circulation of blood in 1628.

Before him, many people believed the liver made blood.